the two sections that he translated, he miserably said they were full of ‘the puerile absurdities of which the eighteen thousand creations may well be amazed…. Such discussion as one never heard! As, Shall I eat forbidden things? Shall I eat turnips? But such is my fate, to be employed on such works.’ There were further humiliations in store for Badauni because Akbar took a very keen interest in the translated pages, and one day summoned Badauni, furious over a line he had just come across in the *Razmnama*: ‘Every action has its reward and every deed its recompense.’

Turning to Abu’l Fazl the Padshah damningly said, ‘We imagined that this person [Badauni], was a young, unworldly adherent of Sufism, but he has turned out to be such a bigoted follower of Islamic law that no sword can slice the jugular vein of his bigotry.’ It took a lot of explanation from Badauni to convince the Padshah that this was, in fact, part of the original text which taught the concepts of rewards and punishments. Akbar, it seemed, was particularly wary of any allusion to the Islamic notion of a Day of Judgement, which was how he had interpreted Badauni’s line. Akbar remained deeply invested and implicated in the translation of the work, judging each line of the translated text and keeping a vigilant watch over any attempt to manipulate the message of the text.

While the scholars and the translators wrestled over the nuances of the Mahabharat in the maktab khana, Akbar conducted a second darbar after the morning’s jharoka darshan. The court had not yet ossified into the rigid and minutely-detailed protocol of the later Mughals, so this second darbar was sometimes held in the morning, or in the evening, or even at night. A large drum would announce the arrival of the Padshah at the hall, while his sons and courtiers would hurry to take their places. Broad-shouldered, powerfully built, and slightly bandy-legged, limping almost imperceptibly in the left leg, Akbar would stride into the darbar. He would be armed, as were all the men. Monserrate wrote that he was especially fond of carrying a European sword and a dagger. He would be surrounded by a bodyguard of twenty men, all armed too. Akbar would sometimes use an octagonal low throne, made of pure white ivory inlaid with gold.

Standing behind him would be young servant boys holding the standard, or alam, wrapped up in an embroidered crimson cloth, to be unfurled in times of war or during parades. Salim was always meant to be placed slightly nearer his father than Murad or Daniyal but Akbar would often pull his younger sons or, later, his grandsons, affectionately closer to him.